

Times Cryptic

No 29604

SATURDAY 25 JULY 2026 · 28 CLUES

One clue at a time. Work it out, and if you stick, climb the hints only as far as you need: where the definition is, what device the setter used, what the wordplay works on, the opening letters, the full parsing — and only then the answer.

Every hint is a tap away on its own page, so nothing is spoiled by reading ahead. Answers live only on the answer pages.

Start with 1 across



Jump to any clue



Clues © The Times / News UK, from the puzzle feed for 25 July 2026. Parsings written for practice; the full solution is verified against the feed's own published grid hash.

All clues

Tap any clue to go straight to it.

ACROSS

- 1A** Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy (6-6)
- 8A** Sky feature artist visiting the East End? (7)
- 9A** Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess (7)
- 11A** Throw our hens nuts (7)
- 12A** Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence (2,3,2)
- 13A** Cream horn barely fills climber (5)
- 14A** I clipped information about energy poverty (9)
- 16A** Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays (6,3)
- 19A** Bird is near lions on a regular basis (5)
- 21A** Caught someone without coat (7)
- 23A** Moving gear's left to the right person at last (7)
- 24A** Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin (7)
- 25A** From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars (7)
- 26A** Socially aware, boring badger in novel (8,4)

DOWN

- 1D** Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze? (7)
- 2D** Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics (7)
- 3D** With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US (3,6)
- 4D** Soldiers and miners climbing peak (5)
- 5D** Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID (7)
- 6D** Content to be at rear of vessel from China? (7)
- 7D** Is painful red bum revealing mistake? (8,4)
- 10D** Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city (5-2-5)
- 15D** Change of course leaves learner failing (9)
- 17D** Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing middle tooth (7)
- 18D** Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son (7)
- 19D** Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing (7)
- 20D** Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister (7)
- 22D** Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south (5)

1 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping
ecstasy
(6-6)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1 Where the definition is >
- 2 What the setter is doing >
- 3 What the wordplay works on >
- 4 The opening letters >
- 5 The full parsing >
- Give up — show the answer >

1 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy
(6 - 6)

Where the definition is

The definition is the very first word — the state of having your head somewhere other than the task.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

1 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy

(6 - 6)

What the setter is doing

"confused" = anagram indicator. "dropping ecstasy" = delete an E (ecstasy = E).

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

1 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy
(6 - 6)

What the wordplay works on

The letters of BEST MAN DENIED (13), minus one E → 12 letters to rearrange.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

1 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy
(6-6)

The opening letters

It begins **A B**, and runs to 12 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



1 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy

(6-6)

The full parsing

BESTMANDENIED is 13 letters; drop one E for "dropping ecstasy" leaving A,B,D,D,E,E,I,M,N,N,S,T. "Confused" anagrams those into [THE ANSWER] — the multiset matches exactly. "and" is just a link word; "Inattentive" is the definition.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

1 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Inattentive and confused best man denied dropping ecstasy

ABSENT - MINDED

HOW IT WORKS

BESTMANDENIED is 13 letters; drop one E for "dropping ecstasy" leaving A,B,D,D,E,E,I,M,N,N,S,T. "Confused" anagrams those into ABSENT-MINDED — the multiset matches exactly. "and" is just a link word; "Inattentive" is the definition.

Definition: The definition is the very first word — the state of having your head somewhere other than the task.

Next clue



8 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



8 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first two words — an arc of colour you look up at after a shower.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

8 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?

(7)

What the setter is doing

"visiting" = IN (a charade link meaning inside/visiting). The "?" flags "the East End" as one specific district, not the area in general.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

8 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?

(7)

What the wordplay works on

artist = RA (Royal Academician); visiting = IN; the East End = BOW, the London district.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

8 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?

(7)

The opening letters

It begins **R A**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



8 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?

(7)

The full parsing

RA (artist) + IN (visiting) + BOW (a district of London's East End) = [THE ANSWER]. Definition: "Sky feature".

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

8 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Sky feature artist visiting the East End?

RAINBOW

HOW IT WORKS

RA (artist) + IN (visiting) + BOW (a district of London's East End) = RAINBOW. Definition: "Sky feature".

Definition: The definition is the first two words — an arc of colour you look up at after a shower.

Next clue



9 ACROSS THE CLUE

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess
(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1 Where the definition is >
- 2 What the setter is doing >
- 3 What the wordplay works on >
- 4 The opening letters >
- 5 The full parsing >
- Give up — show the answer >

9 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word alone — a Greek deity whose name now means someone's inescapable undoing.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

9 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess
(7)

What the setter is doing

"coming back" = reversal. "welcoming" = containment (something is put inside).

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

9 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess
(7)

What the wordplay works on

Saint = S, then I, then spotted = SEEN — reverse the lot; maiden = M goes inside.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

9 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess
(7)

The opening letters

It begins N E, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



9 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess
(7)

The full parsing

S + I + SEEN = SISEEN; "coming back" reverses it to NEESIS;

"welcoming maiden" inserts M (maiden, the cricket abbreviation): NE

+ M + ESIS = [THE ANSWER], the goddess of retribution.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

9 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Saint I spotted coming back, welcoming maiden goddess

NEMESIS

HOW IT WORKS

S + I + SEEN = SISEEN; "coming back" reverses it to NEESIS;
"welcoming maiden" inserts M (maiden, the cricket abbreviation): NE +
M + ESIS = NEMESIS, the goddess of retribution.

Definition: The definition is the last word alone — a Greek deity whose name now means someone's inescapable undoing.

Next clue



11 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Throw our hens nuts
(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1

Where the definition is

>
- 2

What the setter is doing

>
- 3

What the wordplay works on

>
- 4

The opening letters

>
- 5

The full parsing

>
- Give up — show the answer

>

11 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Throw our hens nuts

(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the single first word — what a bucking mount does to its rider.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

11 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Throw our hens nuts

(7)

What the setter is doing

"nuts" = anagram indicator (crazy, mixed up). A three-word clue: definition, fodder, indicator.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

11 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Throw our hens nuts

(7)

What the wordplay works on

OUR HENS — exactly seven letters.

4 Next hint: The opening letters**Back to the clue****Show the answer**

11 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Throw our hens nuts

(7)

The opening lettersIt begins **U N**, and runs to 7 letters in all.**5** Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

11 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Throw our hens nuts

(7)

The full parsing

Anagram ("nuts") of OUR HENS gives the seven letters exactly. The definition is "Throw" — what a horse does to an unwanted rider.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

11 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Throw our hens nuts

UNHORSE

HOW IT WORKS

Anagram ("nuts") of OUR HENS gives the seven letters exactly. The definition is "Throw" — what a horse does to an unwanted rider.

Definition: The definition is the single first word — what a bucking mount does to its rider.

Next clue



12 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence

(2, 3, 2)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



12 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence

(2, 3, 2)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first word alone — never sitting still.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



12 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence
(2,3,2)

What the setter is doing

"initially destroyed" = remove the first letter. Otherwise a straight charade (bits joined end to end).

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

12 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence

(2, 3, 2)

What the wordplay works on

part of year = MONTH (beheaded); self-confidence = EGO.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



12 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence

(2, 3, 2)

The opening letters

It begins **O N**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



12 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence
(2,3,2)

The full parsing

MONTH loses its initial M ("initially destroyed") → ONTH; add EGO (self-confidence) and split the result 2,3,2.

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

12 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Busy part of year initially destroyed self-confidence

ON THE GO

HOW IT WORKS

MONTH loses its initial M ("initially destroyed") → ONTH; add EGO (self-confidence) and split the result 2,3,2.

Definition: The definition is the first word alone — never sitting still.

Next clue



13 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Cream horn barely fills climber

(5)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



13 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Cream horn barely fills climber

(5)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first word — but not the pastry. Think of it as a colour.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

13 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Cream horn barely fills climber

(5)

What the setter is doing

"barely" = strip the outer letters (bare it). "fills" = insertion.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on**Back to the clue****Show the answer**

13 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Cream horn barely fills climber

(5)

What the wordplay works on

HORN bared to its middle = OR; climber = IVY.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



13 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Cream horn barely fills climber

(5)

The opening letters

It begins **I**, and runs to 5 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



13 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Cream horn barely fills climber

(5)

The full parsing

HORN "barely" (stripped bare of H and N) = OR, which "fills" IVY (a climber): IV + OR + Y = [THE ANSWER], a creamy off-white.

"Cream horn" is a deliberate red herring.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

13 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Cream horn barely fills climber

IVORY

HOW IT WORKS

HORN "barely" (stripped bare of H and N) = OR, which "fills" IVY (a climber): IV + OR + Y = IVORY, a creamy off-white. "Cream horn" is a deliberate red herring.

Definition: The definition is the first word — but not the pastry. Think of it as a colour.

Next clue



14 ACROSS

THE CLUE

I clipped information about energy poverty
(9)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1

Where the definition is

>
- 2

What the setter is doing

>
- 3

What the wordplay works on

>
- 4

The opening letters

>
- 5

The full parsing

>
- Give up — show the answer

>

14 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

I clipped information about energy poverty
(9)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — a formal word for destitution.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing

Back to the clue

Show the answer

14 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

I clipped information about energy poverty
(9)

What the setter is doing

"clipped" = drop the final letter. The rest is a charade of abbreviations.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

14 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

I clipped information about energy poverty

(9)

What the wordplay works on

I = INDIA (the radio alphabet), clipped → INDI; information = GEN;
about = C (circa); energy = E.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

14 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

I clipped information about energy poverty
(9)

The opening letters

It begins **I N**, and runs to 9 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

14 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

I clipped information about energy poverty

(9)

The full parsing

INDIA clipped = INDI, + GEN (information) + C (about, circa) + E (energy) = [THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

14 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

I clipped information about energy poverty

INDIGENCE

HOW IT WORKS

INDIA clipped = INDI, + GEN (information) + C (about, circa) + E (energy) = INDIGENCE.

Definition: The definition is the last word — a formal word for destitution.

Next clue



16 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

(6, 3)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



16 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

(6, 3)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first word — a specific stage comedy of the door-slamming, chaos-backstage kind. The answer is also the theatrical term for sounds made out of sight.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

16 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

(6, 3)

What the setter is doing

"plays" = anagram indicator (plays = moves about). "Shakespeare's" supplies the possessive S; "First" takes the initial of Folio.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

16 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

(6, 3)

What the wordplay works on

IS ONE OF + S (Shakespeare's) + F (First of Folio) — nine letters.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



16 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

(6, 3)

The opening letters

It begins N O, and runs to 9 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



16 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

(6, 3)

The full parsing

I,S,O,N,E,O,F plus S plus F, anagrammed ("plays"), gives the nine letters — both sides sort to E,F,F,I,N,O,O,S,S. The definition is "Farce": a Michael Frayn comedy. The Shakespeare surface is pure misdirection.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

16 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Farce is one of Shakespeare's First Folio plays

NOISES OFF**HOW IT WORKS**

I,S,O,N,E,O,F plus S plus F, anagrammed ("plays"), gives the nine letters — both sides sort to E,F,F,I,N,O,O,S,S. The definition is "Farce": a Michael Frayn comedy. The Shakespeare surface is pure misdirection.

Definition: The definition is the first word — a specific stage comedy of the door-slamming, chaos-backstage kind. The answer is also the theatrical term for sounds made out of sight.

Next clue



19 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

(5)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



19 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

(5)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first word — a small yellowish European finch, cousin to the canary.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



19 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

(5)

What the setter is doing

"on a regular basis" = take evenly spaced letters (every second one).

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on



Back to the clue



Show the answer



19 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

(5)

What the wordplay works on

IS NEAR LIONS.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



19 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

(5)

The opening letters

It begins S, and runs to 5 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



19 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

(5)

The full parsing

Take alternate letters of IS NEAR LIONS: i-S-n-E-a-R-l-I-o-N-s = [THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

19 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Bird is near lions on a regular basis

SERIN**HOW IT WORKS**

Take alternate letters of IS NEAR LIONS: i-S-n-E-a-R-l-I-o-N-s = SERIN.

Definition: The definition is the first word — a small yellowish European finch, cousin to the canary.

Next clue



21 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Caught someone without coat

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



21 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Caught someone without coat
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — not an overcoat, but a hard glossy varnish (or to apply one).

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

21 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Caught someone without coat

(7)

What the setter is doing

"Caught" = C, the cricket abbreviation. "without" = positional — outside rather than in.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

21 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Caught someone without coat

(7)

What the wordplay works on

someone = CLAQUER, a member of a clique (a hired applauder); its C is the one "caught".

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

21 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Caught someone without coat

(7)

The opening letters

It begins **L A**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



21 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Caught someone without coat

(7)

The full parsing

Definition: "coat". CLAQUER is "someone"; the caught C is currently without — outside — and belongs inside: C,L,A,Q,U,E,R rearranged to [THE ANSWER]. This is the one clue in the puzzle whose exact device is arguable; the answer itself is confirmed by the checked letters L?C?U?R and by the published grid hash.

Back to the clue



Show the answer



21 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Caught someone without coat

LACQUER

HOW IT WORKS

Definition: "coat". CLAQUER is "someone"; the caught C is currently without — outside — and belongs inside: C,L,A,Q,U,E,R rearranged to LACQUER. This is the one clue in the puzzle whose exact device is arguable; the answer itself is confirmed by the checked letters L?C?U?R and by the published grid hash.

Definition: The definition is the last word — not an overcoat, but a hard glossy varnish (or to apply one).

Next clue



23 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Moving gear's left to the right person at last

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



23 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Moving gear's left to the right person at last
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last three words — and "last" is the shoemaker's foot-shaped form, not the adjective.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

23 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Moving gear's left to the right person at last

(7)

What the setter is doing

"Moving ... left to the right" = shift the letter L rightwards inside the word.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

23 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Moving gear's left to the right person at last
(7)

What the wordplay works on

gear = CLOBBER (slang for kit or clothing).

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



23 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Moving gear's left to the right person at last
(7)

The opening letters

It begins **C O**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



23 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Moving gear's left to the right person at last

(7)

The full parsing

CLOBBER ("gear") with its "left" — the letter L — moved three places to the right. The person defined works at a last, the shoemaker's foot-shaped form.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

23 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Moving gear's left to the right person at last

COBBLER**HOW IT WORKS**

CLOBBER ("gear") with its "left" — the letter L — moved three places to the right. The person defined works at a last, the shoemaker's foot-shaped form.

Definition: The definition is the last three words — and "last" is the shoemaker's foot-shaped form, not the adjective.

Next clue



24 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit
of Amazon basin
(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1

Where the definition is

>
- 2

What the setter is doing

>
- 3

What the wordplay works on

>
- 4

The opening letters

>
- 5

The full parsing

>
- Give up — show the answer

>

24 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — a stone basin beside a church altar for rinsing the sacred vessels.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing

Back to the clue

Show the answer

24 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin
(7)

What the setter is doing

"guarding" = containment. "final bit of" = last letter only.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on



Back to the clue



Show the answer



24 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin
(7)

What the wordplay works on

private investigators = PIS; spy agency = CIA; final bit of Amazon = N.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

24 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin
(7)

The opening letters

It begins **P I**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing

Back to the clue

Show the answer

24 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin
(7)

The full parsing

PIS + CIA guarding N (the last letter of AmazoN) = PIS + CI-N-A =
[THE ANSWER].

Back to the clue



Show the answer



24 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Private investigators spy agency guarding final bit of Amazon basin

PISCINA

HOW IT WORKS

PIS + CIA guarding N (the last letter of AmazoN) = PIS + CI-N-A = PISCINA.

Definition: The definition is the last word — a stone basin beside a church altar for rinsing the sacred vessels.

Next clue



25 ACROSS

THE CLUE

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars
(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



25 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first three words — the peninsula Spain and Portugal share.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

25 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars
(7)

What the setter is doing

"about" = reversal. "bars" = containment (confines, keeps behind bars).

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on



Back to the clue



Show the answer



25 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars
(7)

What the wordplay works on

live = BE; broadcast = AIR (reversed → RIA); popular = IN, doing the containing.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

25 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars
(7)

The opening letters

It begins **I B**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

25 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars
(7)

The full parsing

IN "bars" BE + RIA: I(BE·RIA)N = [THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

25 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

From a peninsula, live broadcast about popular bars

IBERIAN

HOW IT WORKS

IN "bars" BE + RIA: I(BE·RIA)N = IBERIAN.

Definition: The definition is the first three words — the peninsula Spain and Portugal share.

Next clue



26 ACROSS

THE CLUE

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

(8,4)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1

Where the definition is

>
- 2

What the setter is doing

>
- 3

What the wordplay works on

>
- 4

The opening letters

>
- 5

The full parsing

>
- Give up — show the answer

>

26 ACROSS

HINT 1 OF 5

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

(8, 4)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — a 1938 Graham Greene book set in a south-coast resort, with a razor-gang anti-hero.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

26 ACROSS

HINT 2 OF 5

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

(8, 4)

What the setter is doing

"boring" = insertion (drilling into). "badger" is the noun, not the verb.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on



Back to the clue



Show the answer



26 ACROSS

HINT 3 OF 5

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

(8, 4)

What the wordplay works on

Socially aware = RIGHT ON; badger = BROCK.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



26 ACROSS

HINT 4 OF 5

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

(8,4)

The opening letters

It begins **B R**, and runs to 12 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



26 ACROSS

HINT 5 OF 5

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

(8,4)

The full parsing

RIGHT ON bores into BROCK: B(RIGHTON)ROCK = [THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

26 ACROSS

THE ANSWER

Socially aware, boring badger in novel

BRIGHTON ROCK

HOW IT WORKS

RIGHT ON bores into BROCK: B(RIGHTON)ROCK = BRIGHTON ROCK.

Definition: The definition is the last word — a 1938 Graham Greene book set in a south-coast resort, with a razor-gang anti-hero.

Next clue



1 DOWN

THE CLUE

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is**2 What the setter is doing****3 What the wordplay works on****4 The opening letters****5 The full parsing****Give up — show the answer**

1 DOWN HINT 1 OF 5

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — and the answer is the noise itself, spelled out.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

1 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?

(7)

What the setter is doing

"stifling" = hidden-word indicator; the surrounding words smother the answer.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

1 DOWN HINT 3 OF 5

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?
(7)

What the wordplay works on

Run the first three words together and look inside: downbe|[THE ANSWER]|dlum.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

1 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?

(7)

The opening letters

It begins **A T**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



1 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?

(7)

The full parsing

Write the first three words as one string and the answer is sitting inside it, spanning the joins: downbe / [THE ANSWER] / dlum. The definition is "sneeze?" — the question mark because the answer is the written imitation of one.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

1 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Downbeat, is hoodlum stifling sneeze?

ATISHOO

HOW IT WORKS

Write the first three words as one string and the answer is sitting inside it, spanning the joins: downbe / at is hoo / dlum. The definition is "sneeze?" — the question mark because the answer is the written imitation of one.

Definition: The definition is the last word — and the answer is the noise itself, spelled out.

Next clue



2 DOWN

THE CLUE

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



2 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last two words — in a restrained, unshowy manner.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

2 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics
(7)

What the setter is doing

"extremely" = take the outermost letters of the next word. "to accept" = containment.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

2 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics
(7)

What the wordplay works on

Sister = SR; extremes of LIKELY = L,Y; award = OBE.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

2 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics
(7)

The opening letters

It begins **S O**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

2 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics
(7)

The full parsing

SR + LY = SRLY, which "accepts" OBE (the award): S(OBE)RLY =
[THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

2 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Sister extremely likely to accept award without histrionics

SOBERLY**HOW IT WORKS**

SR + LY = SRLY, which "accepts" OBE (the award): S(OBE)RLY = SOBERLY.

Definition: The definition is the last two words — in a restrained, unshowy manner.

Next clue



3 DOWN

THE CLUE

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US

(3,6)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



3 DOWN HINT 1 OF 5

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US
(3, 6)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last four words — one of the fifty states, down in the southwest.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

3 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US
(3, 6)

What the setter is doing

"travelling around" = anagram indicator.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on**Back to the clue****Show the answer**

3 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US
(3, 6)

What the wordplay works on

With = W, European = E, EX-CON, I'm = IM → W,E,E,X,C,O,N,I,M.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

3 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US
(3, 6)

The opening letters

It begins N E, and runs to 9 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



3 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US

(3, 6)

The full parsing

Those nine letters, anagrammed, give [THE ANSWER] — both sides sort to C,E,E,I,M,N,O,W,X.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

3 DOWN

THE ANSWER

With European ex-con, I'm travelling around part of the US

NEW MEXICO

HOW IT WORKS

Those nine letters, anagrammed, give NEW MEXICO — both sides sort to C,E,E,I,M,N,O,W,X.

Definition: The definition is the last four words — one of the fifty states, down in the southwest.

Next clue



4 DOWN

THE CLUE

Soldiers and miners climbing peak

(5)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU**1 Where the definition is****2 What the setter is doing****3 What the wordplay works on****4 The opening letters****5 The full parsing****Give up — show the answer**

4 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Soldiers and miners climbing peak
(5)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — specifically a Scottish one over 3,000 feet, the kind hillwalkers collect.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing

Back to the clue

Show the answer

4 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Soldiers and miners climbing peak

(5)

What the setter is doing

"climbing" = reversal (upwards, since this is a down clue) — and it reads beautifully with the mountain surface.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

4 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Soldiers and miners climbing peak

(5)

What the wordplay works on

soldiers = OR (other ranks); miners = NUM (National Union of Mineworkers).

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

4 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Soldiers and miners climbing peak

(5)

The opening letters

It begins **M**, and runs to 5 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



4 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Soldiers and miners climbing peak

(5)

The full parsing

OR + NUM = ORNUM, climbing (reversed up the grid) = [THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

4 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Soldiers and miners climbing peak

MUNRO

HOW IT WORKS

OR + NUM = ORNUM, climbing (reversed up the grid) = MUNRO.

Definition: The definition is the last word — specifically a Scottish one over 3,000 feet, the kind hillwalkers collect.

Next clue



5 DOWN

THE CLUE

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID (7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



5 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — the badge pinned on at a conference.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



5 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID

(7)

What the setter is doing

"Swapping the headings of" = exchange the first letters of the two words that follow.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

5 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID
(7)

What the wordplay works on

domesticated horse = TAME NAG.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



5 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID
(7)

The opening letters

It begins N A, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

5 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID

(7)

The full parsing

TAME NAG with its headings swapped ($T \leftrightarrow N$) = [THE ANSWER],
an ID.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

5 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Swapping the headings of domesticated horse's ID

NAMETAG**HOW IT WORKS**

TAME NAG with its headings swapped ($T \leftrightarrow N$) = NAME TAG, an ID.

Definition: The definition is the last word — the badge pinned on at a conference.

Next clue



6 DOWN

THE CLUE

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



6 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last two words — the "?" means China is just an example of somewhere in that direction.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

6 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

(7)

What the setter is doing

"Content" = take the inside letters (outers dropped). "?" = definition by example.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

6 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

(7)

What the wordplay works on

the content of "be at" = EA; rear of vessel = STERN.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



6 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

(7)

The opening letters

It begins **E A**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



6 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

(7)

The full parsing

EA (inside of BE AT) + STERN (rear of a vessel) = [THE ANSWER].
It also reads as E (content of "be") + ASTERN.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

6 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Content to be at rear of vessel from China?

EASTERN**HOW IT WORKS**

EA (inside of BE AT) + STERN (rear of a vessel) = EASTERN. It also reads as E (content of "be") + ASTERN.

Definition: The definition is the last two words — the "?" means China is just an example of somewhere in that direction.

Next clue



7 DOWN

THE CLUE

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

(8, 4)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



7 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

(8, 4)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last two words — the sort of slip that accidentally exposes what you were really thinking.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

7 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

(8,4)

What the setter is doing

"bum" = anagram indicator (bum meaning faulty/duff).

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on



Back to the clue



Show the answer



7 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

(8,4)

What the wordplay works on

IS PAINFUL RED — twelve letters.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



7 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

(8, 4)

The opening letters

It begins **F R**, and runs to 12 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



7 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

(8, 4)

The full parsing

Anagram of ISPAINFULRED = [THE ANSWER]; both sort to A,D,E,F,I,I,L,N,P,R,S,U. Split 8,4.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

7 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Is painful red bum revealing mistake?

FREUDIAN SLIP

HOW IT WORKS

Anagram of ISPAINFULRED = FREUDIANS LIP; both sort to A,D,E,F,I,I,L,N,P,R,S,U. Split 8,4.

Definition: The definition is the last two words — the sort of slip that accidentally exposes what you were really thinking.

Next clue



10 DOWN

THE CLUE

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city

(5-2-5)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



10 DOWN HINT 1 OF 5

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city
(5-2-5)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — a Staffordshire one, famous for its potteries.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

10 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city

(5-2-5)

What the setter is doing

"saves" = containment (holds something inside). Otherwise a charade of abbreviations run together.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

10 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city

(5-2-5)

What the wordplay works on

Small = S; indication = TOKEN, which saves nothing (O) inside it;
Tesla = T (the SI unit); lease = RENT.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

10 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city

(5-2-5)

The opening letters

It begins **S T**, and runs to 12 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing



Back to the clue



Show the answer



10 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city

(5-2-5)

The full parsing

S + TOKEN with O (nothing) saved inside → TOKE-O-N, + T (tesla) +
RENT (lease) = [THE ANSWER], split 5-2-5.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

10 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Small indication Tesla lease saves nothing for city

STOKE-ON-TRENT

HOW IT WORKS

S + TOKEN with O (nothing) saved inside → TOKE-O-N, + T (tesla) + RENT (lease) = STOKEONTRENT, split 5-2-5.

Definition: The definition is the last word — a Staffordshire one, famous for its potteries.

Next clue



15 DOWN

THE CLUE

Change of course leaves learner failing

(9)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU**1 Where the definition is****2 What the setter is doing****3 What the wordplay works on****4 The opening letters****5 The full parsing****Give up — show the answer**

15 DOWN HINT 1 OF 5

Change of course leaves learner failing
(9)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — in its older sense of a lapse or failure in duty, i.e. going over to the other side.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

15 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Change of course leaves learner failing

(9)

What the setter is doing

"leaves" = deletion (loses); "learner" = L, the learner-driver plate.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on



Back to the clue



Show the answer



15 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Change of course leaves learner failing

(9)

What the wordplay works on

Change of course = DEFLECTION.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



15 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Change of course leaves learner failing
(9)

The opening letters

It begins **D E**, and runs to 9 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

15 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Change of course leaves learner failing

(9)

The full parsing

DEFLECTION (a change of course) leaves its learner — drops the L — giving [THE ANSWER], a failing in duty.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

15 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Change of course leaves learner failing

DEFECTION

HOW IT WORKS

DEFLECTION (a change of course) leaves its learner — drops the L — giving DEFECTION, a failing in duty.

Definition: The definition is the last word — in its older sense of a lapse or failure in duty, i.e. going over to the other side.

Next clue



17 DOWN

THE CLUE

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary
composer missing middle tooth

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1 Where the definition is >
- 2 What the setter is doing >
- 3 What the wordplay works on >
- 4 The opening letters >
- 5 The full parsing >
- Give up — show the answer >

17 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing
middle tooth

(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — one of the cutting ones at the front of
your mouth.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

17 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing
middle tooth

(7)

What the setter is doing

"Opening of" = first letter. "penned by" = insertion (the letter goes inside). "revolutionary" = reversal. "missing middle" = drop the central letter.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

17 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing
middle tooth

(7)

What the wordplay works on

C (opening of Concerto) goes inside ROSSINI, which has lost its
middle letter and been turned round.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

17 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing middle tooth

(7)

The opening letters

It begins I N, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5

Next hint: The full parsing

>

Back to the clue

>

Show the answer

>

17 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing middle tooth

(7)

The full parsing

ROSSINI (composer) missing its middle letter → ROSINI;
"revolutionary" reverses that to INISOR; C (opening of Concerto) is then penned by it, slotting in after the first two letters.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

17 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Opening of concerto penned by revolutionary composer missing middle tooth

INCISOR**HOW IT WORKS**

ROSSINI (composer) missing its middle letter → ROSINI;
"revolutionary" reverses that to INISOR; C (opening of Concerto) is then
penned by it, slotting in after the first two letters.

Definition: The definition is the last word — one of the cutting ones at the front of your mouth.

Next clue



18 DOWN

THE CLUE

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter,
not son

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is >

2 What the setter is doing >

3 What the wordplay works on >

4 The opening letters >

5 The full parsing >

Give up — show the answer >

18 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first word — oozing something out, as a plant does sap.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

18 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son
(7)

What the setter is doing

"with ... not ..." = letter substitution: swap a D in for an S.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

18 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son
(7)

What the wordplay works on

former partner = EX; on drugs = USING; daughter = D replaces son = S.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

18 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son
(7)

The opening letters

It begins **E X**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

18 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son
(7)

The full parsing

EX + USING, with D (daughter) in place of S (son): USING →
UDING. EX + Uding = [THE ANSWER].

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

18 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Releasing former partner on drugs with daughter, not son

EXUDING**HOW IT WORKS**

EX + USING, with D (daughter) in place of S (son): USING → UDING.
EX + UDING = EXUDING.

Definition: The definition is the first word — oozing something out, as a plant does sap.

Next clue



19 DOWN

THE CLUE

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is
flipping freezing
(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1 Where the definition is >
- 2 What the setter is doing >
- 3 What the wordplay works on >
- 4 The opening letters >
- 5 The full parsing >
- Give up — show the answer >

19 DOWN HINT 1 OF 5

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing
(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the last word — below the point where water turns to ice.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

19 DOWN HINT 2 OF 5

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing
(7)

What the setter is doing

"is flipping" = reversal (upwards, in a down clue). "carrying" joins the parts.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

19 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing
(7)

What the wordplay works on

Old = O, vehicle = BUS, carrying army corps = RE and Zulu = Z.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

19 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing
(7)

The opening letters

It begins S U, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing

Back to the clue

Show the answer

19 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing
(7)

The full parsing

O + BUS carrying RE and Z gives OREZBUS; "is flipping" turns it round to [THE ANSWER], i.e. freezing.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

19 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Old vehicle carrying army corps and Zulu is flipping freezing

SUBZERO

HOW IT WORKS

O + BUS carrying RE and Z gives OREZBUS; "is flipping" turns it round to SUBZERO, i.e. freezing.

Definition: The definition is the last word — below the point where water turns to ice.

Next clue



20 DOWN

THE CLUE

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister

(7)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

1 Where the definition is



2 What the setter is doing



3 What the wordplay works on



4 The opening letters



5 The full parsing



Give up — show the answer



20 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister

(7)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first two words — to behave in a boisterous, high-spirited way.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

20 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister
(7)

What the setter is doing

"retired" = reversal. The rest is a charade.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

20 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister
(7)

What the wordplay works on

turn = ROLL; one = I; barrister = KC (King's Counsel), retired → CK.

4 Next hint: The opening letters >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

20 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister
(7)

The opening letters

It begins **R O**, and runs to 7 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

20 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister

(7)

The full parsing

ROLL (turn) + I (one) + KC reversed ("retired barrister"), read in that order down the grid.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

20 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Act carefree to turn on one retired barrister

ROLICK**HOW IT WORKS**

ROLL (turn) + I (one) + KC reversed ("retired barrister"), read in that order down the grid.

Definition: The definition is the first two words — to behave in a boisterous, high-spirited way.

Next clue



22 DOWN THE CLUE

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south
(5)

Type here if your viewer allows it, or keep it in your head.

HINTS — TAKE THE LOWEST RUNG THAT UNSTICKS YOU

- 1 Where the definition is >
- 2 What the setter is doing >
- 3 What the wordplay works on >
- 4 The opening letters >
- 5 The full parsing >
- Give up — show the answer >

22 DOWN

HINT 1 OF 5

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south

(5)

Where the definition is

The definition is the first two words — to give someone a scorching dressing-down.

2 Next hint: What the setter is doing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

22 DOWN

HINT 2 OF 5

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south

(5)

What the setter is doing

"from the south" = reversal upwards in a down clue. "taking" = containment. "over" = O, the cricket abbreviation.

3 Next hint: What the wordplay works on >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

22 DOWN

HINT 3 OF 5

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south

(5)

What the wordplay works on

emperor = TSAR, read from the south → RAST; it takes in O.

4 Next hint: The opening letters



Back to the clue



Show the answer



22 DOWN

HINT 4 OF 5

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south
(5)

The opening letters

It begins **R**, and runs to 5 letters in all.

5 Next hint: The full parsing >

Back to the clue >

Show the answer >

22 DOWN

HINT 5 OF 5

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south

(5)

The full parsing

TSAR (emperor) read from the south = RAST, and O (over) is taken in straight after the R.

[Back to the clue](#)[Show the answer](#)

22 DOWN

THE ANSWER

Severely criticise emperor taking over from the south

ROAST

HOW IT WORKS

TSAR (emperor) read from the south = RAST, and O (over) is taken in straight after the R.

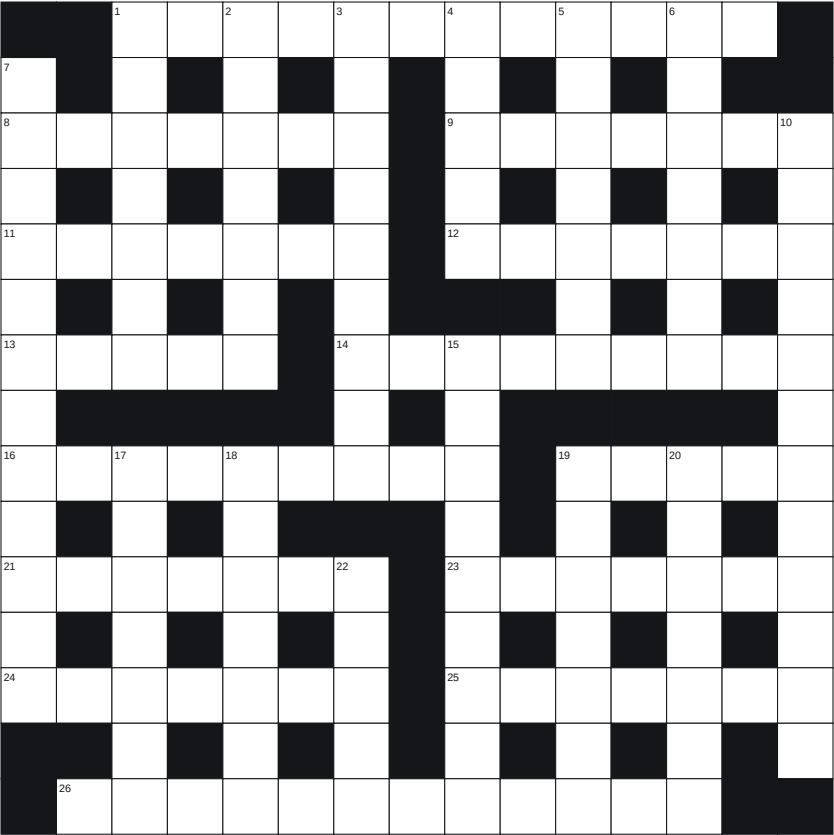
Definition: The definition is the first two words — to give someone a scorching dressing-down.

[Back to all clues](#)



The grid

Blank, if you would rather solve it the usual way.



[Back to all clues](#)

